

AI Adoption

GLOSSARY 04 - SHEET 1 / 8

The process by which an approved AI system becomes routine practice in the operating business

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

AI adoption is the process by which an approved artificial intelligence system passes from availability into routine use in the operating business, such that the work is genuinely performed differently and the intended benefit is realised. Adoption is distinguished from deployment, which is a technical event, and from acceptance, which is an attitude; only adoption is observable in changed behaviour and changed outcomes (Rogers, 2003; Fichman, 2000).

WHO DEFINED IT ORIGINALLY

The organisational adoption construct derives from Everett M. Rogers's diffusion of innovations (1962; 5th edn 2003) and from Robert G. Fichman's (2000) synthesis of the information-technology diffusion literature, which distinguished organisational assimilation from individual acceptance. The two-stage structure of adoption decision followed by implementation is Zaltman, Duncan and Holbek's (1973).

WHY THIS DEFINITION WAS DEVELOPED

Firms measured deployment - systems in production - and reported it as adoption, which concealed the gap in which most value is lost. A construct anchored in changed practice rather than in system availability was required to make that gap measurable and therefore manageable.

FIGURE 1 - WHERE THE VALUE IS LOST

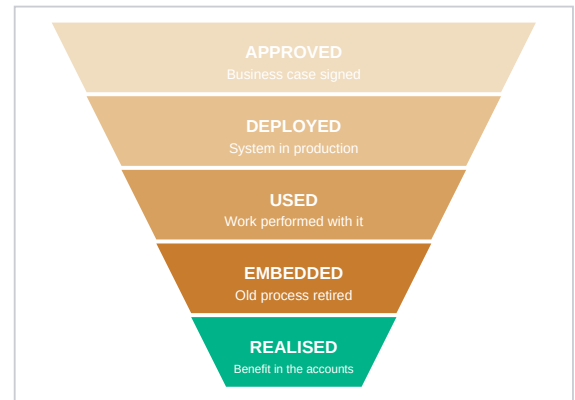


Figure 1. Most AI programmes are measured at the second stage and reported as complete there. The attrition between deployment and embedding is not a technical loss and cannot be recovered by technical means (after Fichman, 2000).

HOW IT IS USED

Measure adoption at the level of the task, using rates of actual use and, more importantly, the operational outcome the system was intended to change; treat any gap between deployment and use as the object of management attention.

WHEN IT IS USED

From the first day of availability rather than at the end of the project, at every stage-gate review, and when benefits promised in the business case have not appeared despite a working system.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Adoption and change leads, business unit managers whose teams must work differently, benefits owners, and the programme office reporting realisation to the executive.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

The predecessor measure was go-live: a project was complete when the system entered production, and any subsequent shortfall was treated as a user problem. Framing adoption as a distinct organisational process with its own owner, timeline and budget makes the post-deployment period a managed phase rather than an unmanaged residue, and reallocates resources to the point where value is actually created or lost.

RELATED DEFINITIONS IN THIS COURSE

Change Management - Unit 4

Technology Acceptance Model - Unit 4

Technology Adoption Lifecycle - Unit 1

Benefits Realisation - Unit 4

Organisational Culture - Unit 2

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Fichman, R.G. (2000) 'The diffusion and assimilation of information technology innovations', in Zmud, R.W. (ed.) Framing the Domains of IT Management. Cincinnati, OH: Pinnaflex, pp. 105-127.

Rogers, E.M. (2003) Diffusion of Innovations. 5th edn. New York: Free Press.

Zaltman, G., Duncan, R. and Holbek, J. (1973) Innovations and Organizations. New York: John Wiley & Sons.